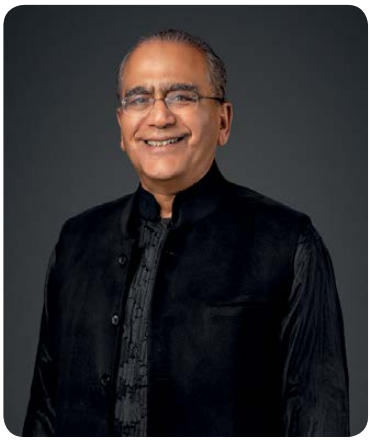
THE SHE LIST

FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Indian women have been on the rise for the past few decades. It has now become very evident. India's leading astrophysicist. Space entrepreneurs. A scientist at the helm of our mission to the Sun. A bureaucrat who runs the Indian railways down here on terra firma. Supreme Court justices. CEOs of major multinational corporations. Owners of businesses that span the gamut from healthcare, technology, software, pharma and banks to conglomerates in the buzzing world of social media and entertainment. Chairperson of SEBI. A vice-chancellor. A vice admiral. A champion boxer. A crack commando trainer. They are all women. And these are but a few of the leading examples of women who have shattered the glass ceiling in style.

There are compelling reasons to honour those who "hold up half the sky", as Mao once said. The annual AISHE (All India Survey on Higher Education) reports recorded an 18.2 per cent rise in female university enrolment between 2015 and 2020 and now estimates that almost 50 per cent of college students are women for the first time: well over 20 million. So, platoons of educated women are waiting in the wings to follow in the footsteps of those who are already successful. A survey by online assessment platform Wheebox put female employability over 52 per cent, way more than of men. Up the value chain, an EY report found that the average representation of women on boards grew to only 18 per cent in 2022, but that's a rapid rise from 6 per cent in 2013. Logic is spurring this, not tokenism. With 70 per cent of global consumption being women-led, all studies show companies with 'women on board' perform way better. India is just entering that virtuous cycle. An uptick is bound to follow in women's share in the so-called C-Suite (CEO, CFO, COO, et al), currently 4.7 per cent for CEOs. It is encouraging to see 44.4 per cent of women's presence in local self-government being among the best in the world. Reservations in panchayats and urban local bodies, 50 per cent in some states, ensured that. What began at the grassroots is now, happily, spreading to the top: the Women's Reservation Bill 2023 commits one-third of our legislatures to them. With only 78 women MPs elected in 2019, a shocking 14 per cent of our 543-seat Lok Sabha, the feminisation of our polity will only be complete when that law takes effect. The women's vote, which at 67.18 per cent outstripped that of men for the first time in 2019 and proved decisive even in the recent state polls, should rev up that process.



As INDIA TODAY completes 48 years of existence, we take this moment to celebrate the achievements of 100 women, a remarkable 'She List' of personalities who have conquered all manner of odds—poverty, gender disparity, inherent and unconscious bias, lack of opportunity and capital, among other things—to make their way to the very top of their professions. These are realms as varied as politics, business, law, science, education, sports, social work, the arts, entertainment and culture. It is by no means an exhaustive list, given the countless number of women achievers in the country, but it shines a light on those who have shone the brightest.

Take the women in science. It gets lonely in this predominantly male bastion. But that hasn't stopped an Annapurni Subramaniam from reaching for the stars, as director of the Indian Institute of Astrophysics. As a young girl, staring at the Milky Way, she knew she would do "anything to do with stars". Or Nigar Shaji from chasing the Sun, as project director of India's solar mission Aditya. Her father's stories of Marie Curie kindled in her an abiding interest in science.

Women are a minority in the armed forces as well. Chandrika Kaushik, the face of Aatmanirbhar Bharat in defence, recounts how she is often the only woman in the room but isn't afraid to speak her mind. Seema Rao, India's only female commando trainer, was a frail girl "scared of water, heights and fire" before training in Bruce Lee's mixed martial art Jeet Kune Do and Israeli Krav Maga and finding her calling in commando training. Not only is she cracking alpha male myths, but has also studied Immunology at Harvard Medical School, is a six-time TEDx speaker and a Mrs India World runner-up.

Women in business form the most significant component. They always have, since the late '80s. There was such a surge in women entrepreneurs then, we dedicated a whole issue to